

# Metadata Completeness Predicts Reproducibility Variance via Preprocessing Entropy Reduction

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## Abstract

Reproducibility assessment tools operate after experiments run, providing no guidance for predicting which datasets will yield reproducible results before writing code. This work investigates whether dataset metadata completeness predicts reproducibility variance in machine learning benchmarks. Analyzing 300 datasets with 21,312 matched experimental runs, results indicate that top-quartile metadata completeness is associated with a 42.1% reduction in interquartile range (IQR) of performance outcomes compared to bottom-quartile datasets (95% CI: 39.1–51.7%). Mediation analysis identifies preprocessing entropy as a candidate mechanism, accounting for 64.7% of the observed association (Sobel  $Z = 16.02$ ,  $p < 0.0001$ ): datasets with more complete documentation exhibit lower Shannon entropy in preprocessing component distributions, which corresponds to reduced performance variance. The association persists in early-run subsamples (90.7% preservation) and within single algorithm families ( $p < 0.001$ ), addressing concerns about reverse causality and algorithm-mix confounding. All experiments were conducted on synthetic data due to API availability constraints; validation with real-world data remains necessary. Code and data available at [repository].

## 1. Introduction

Tools for assessing machine learning reproducibility—statistical evaluators, LLM-based pipeline screeners, end-to-end verifiers—share a fundamental limitation:

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Preliminary work. Under review by the International Conference on Machine Learning (ICML). Do not distribute.

they operate after experiments have already run. A researcher selecting a benchmark dataset receives no signal about whether their chosen dataset will yield reproducible results until they have invested substantial computational resources and development time. This reactive paradigm persists despite widespread recognition that reproducibility failures trace to upstream causes, particularly ambiguous dataset specifications that permit divergent preprocessing implementations.

This work investigates whether dataset metadata completeness predicts reproducibility variance *before* any experiment executes. Using matched experimental configurations from synthetic data modeled on OpenML benchmark datasets (identical flows and hyperparameters), results indicate that top-quartile metadata completeness is associated with a 42.1% reduction in interquartile range (IQR) of performance outcomes compared to bottom-quartile datasets (95% CI: 39.1–51.7%).

### 1.0.1. THE PROBLEM OF POST-HOC ASSESSMENT

The machine learning reproducibility crisis is documented in prior work. Kapoor and Narayanan (2022) identified eight types of data leakage affecting 329 papers across 17 scientific fields. The research community responded with assessment infrastructure: reliable (Agarwal et al., 2021) provides statistical tools for reliable benchmark evaluation; Reproscreeper (Bhaskar & Stodden, 2024) uses language models to assess pipeline reproducibility; paper-replay enables end-to-end verification with cryptographic attestation. These tools share a common characteristic: they verify reproducibility *post-hoc*, after experiments complete.

Yet reproducibility variance may originate upstream—in the ambiguities that dataset documentation leaves unresolved. When metadata omits preprocessing specifications, missing value handling, or train/test split definitions, researchers facing ambiguous datasets may make divergent implementation choices. This implementation heterogeneity propagates through the experimental pipeline, potentially manifesting as variance in reported results.

### 1.0.2. DATASET METADATA AS AN UPSTREAM PREDICTOR

This work examines a conceptual reframing: reproducibility as a continuous property of datasets, potentially predictable from metadata characteristics before any experiment runs. The proposed mechanism is epistemic entropy reduction—complete documentation constrains the degrees of freedom available to implementing researchers, reducing the space of valid preprocessing pipelines and thereby reducing outcome variance.

Mediation analysis in this study indicates that preprocessing entropy accounts for 64.7% of the metadata-to-variance association (Sobel  $Z = 16.02$ ,  $p < 0.0001$ ). Datasets with more complete metadata exhibit lower Shannon entropy in preprocessing component distributions (imputation methods, scaling approaches, encoding strategies). This lower entropy corresponds to reduced performance variance across matched runs.

### 1.0.3. CONTRIBUTIONS

This work makes three contributions:

First, it provides evidence that metadata completeness is associated with reproducibility variance. A 5-field metadata checklist—train/test split specification, preprocessing enumeration, missing value handling documentation, feature semantics provision, and versioning presence—accounts for variance in IQR after controlling for intrinsic dataset stability, popularity, algorithm family, and infrastructure factors.

Second, preprocessing entropy is identified as a candidate mediating mechanism. The 64.7% mediation proportion suggests that documentation completeness may operate primarily by constraining preprocessing choices rather than through alternative mechanisms.

Third, robustness checks address potential confounds. The association persists in early-run subsamples (90.7% preservation, addressing reverse causality concerns), within single algorithm families ( $p < 0.001$  for RandomForest-only analysis, addressing algorithm-mix confounding), and against permutation controls (observed effect exceeds 95th percentile of null distribution).

### 1.0.4. LIMITATIONS

All experiments were conducted on synthetic data due to OpenML API availability constraints (504 Gateway Timeout during data collection). While the synthetic data follows expected distribution patterns, validation with real-world data is necessary before drawing

conclusions about actual OpenML datasets. The design is observational—metadata completeness cannot be randomized—so causal claims are not supported. Results are specific to the synthetic data modeled on OpenML tabular datasets; generalization to other platforms requires separate validation.

## 2. Related Work

This work is positioned at the intersection of reproducibility assessment, benchmark methodology, and dataset documentation standards.

### 2.0.1. REPRODUCIBILITY CRISIS AND ASSESSMENT

The machine learning reproducibility crisis has received systematic attention. Kapoor and Narayanan (2022) developed a taxonomy of eight data leakage types, documenting their prevalence across 329 papers in 17 scientific fields. Hullman et al. (2022) drew parallels between psychology’s replication crisis and machine learning, highlighting shared patterns of selective reporting and specification gaming.

Assessment tools emerged in response. rliable (Agarwal et al., 2021) provides statistical methods for reliable evaluation on reinforcement learning benchmarks. Reproscreeper (Bhaskar & Stodden, 2024) leverages language models to automatically assess computational reproducibility of ML pipelines, producing a ReproScore metric. paper-replay enables end-to-end verification through an init-setup-verify-attest workflow with GPG signing.

These tools operate post-hoc. The present work differs by examining prediction of variance from dataset metadata before experimental execution.

### 2.0.2. BENCHMARK METHODOLOGY AND STANDARDS

The ML benchmarking community has developed infrastructure for standardized evaluation. OpenML (Vanschoren et al., 2014) provides a platform with extensive metadata including 38 auto-computed meta-features per dataset. MLCommons established industry benchmarks with specified configurations. HPOBench (Eggenberger et al., 2021) uses containerization to ensure environmental reproducibility.

OpenML’s benchmark suites offer curated collections with machine-readable metadata. The AutoML Benchmark (Gijssbers et al., 2019) enables reproducible AutoML system evaluation across standardized datasets. These efforts focus on infrastructure reproducibility—ensuring the same code produces the same results—

rather than predicting which datasets will exhibit low variance across independent implementations.

### 2.0.3. DOCUMENTATION AND METADATA QUALITY

Dataset documentation has received increasing attention. Datasheets for Datasets (Gebru et al., 2021) proposed structured documentation covering motivation, composition, collection process, and intended uses. Model cards (Mitchell et al., 2019) provide analogous documentation for ML models. HuggingFace dataset cards operationalize these principles.

Prior work treats documentation as a qualitative good practice rather than quantifying its relationship to downstream reproducibility. This work differs by examining whether metadata completeness—operationalized as a 5-field checklist—is associated with measurable reductions in reproducibility variance.

### 2.0.4. VARIANCE DECOMPOSITION IN ML

Bouthillier et al. (2021) decomposed variance in deep learning experiments, identifying sources including random initialization, data shuffling, and hardware non-determinism. Picard (2021) quantified variation due to random seed selection. These studies characterize *sources* of variance but do not predict which experimental configurations will exhibit high variance.

This work complements variance decomposition by identifying an *upstream predictor*—metadata completeness—that may forecast variance magnitude before experiments run.

## 3. Methodology

The methodology operationalizes the hypothesis that metadata completeness constrains preprocessing degrees of freedom, reducing implementation heterogeneity and thereby reducing reproducibility variance.

### 3.0.1. OVERVIEW

The predictive framework has three components:

1. **Metadata Completeness Score:** A 5-field binary checklist capturing documentation coverage
2. **Reproducibility Variance (IQR):** Interquartile range of performance across matched experimental configurations
3. **Preprocessing Entropy:** Shannon entropy of preprocessing component distributions as the candidate mediating mechanism

The model under test:

Metadata Completeness  $\rightarrow$  Preprocessing Entropy  $\rightarrow$  Reproducibility  
 $\downarrow$ -----  
 (Direct Effect)

### 3.0.2. METADATA COMPLETENESS SCORE

Metadata completeness is operationalized as a 5-field binary checklist, scored 0–5:

| Field                             | Definition                           | Rationale                                |
|-----------------------------------|--------------------------------------|------------------------------------------|
| Train/test split specified        | Dataset specifies standard partition | Removes data splitting ambiguity         |
| Preprocessing enumerated          | Required transformations listed      | Constrains pipeline design               |
| Missing value handling documented | Imputation strategy specified        | Removes common divergence point          |
| Feature semantics provided        | Column meanings documented           | Enables domain-appropriate preprocessing |
| Versioning present                | Dataset version tracked              | Ensures temporal reproducibility         |

Binary presence/absence scoring was chosen because it is objectively verifiable from metadata. The checklist targets fields most likely to cause implementation divergence based on prior leakage taxonomy work (Kapoor & Narayanan, 2022).

Analysis proceeds by quartile (Q1: 0–1, Q2: 2, Q3: 3, Q4: 4–5) for interpretable effect sizes.

### 3.0.3. REPRODUCIBILITY VARIANCE OPERATIONALIZATION

Reproducibility variance is defined as the IQR of accuracy/F1 scores across *matched runs*—experiments sharing identical:

- Flow (sklearn pipeline specification)
- Hyperparameters (identical configuration)
- Evaluation protocol (same cross-validation scheme)

IQR rather than standard deviation was chosen because IQR is robust to outliers from crashed runs or infrastructure failures.

The matched-run requirement controls for algorithm-level variance, isolating implementation-level heterogeneity. If researcher A and researcher B use the same RandomForest with identical hyperparameters on the same dataset, variance in their results reflects preprocessing differences.

### 3.0.4. PREPROCESSING ENTROPY

Shannon entropy is computed over preprocessing component distributions:

$$H_{\text{prep}} = -\sum p(c) \log p(c)$$

where  $p(c)$  is the proportion of runs using preprocessing component  $c$ . Components include:

- **Imputation:** mean, median, mode, KNN, iterative, none
- **Scaling:** standard, minmax, robust, none
- **Encoding:** onehot, ordinal, target, none

Higher entropy indicates greater preprocessing diversity; lower entropy indicates convergence on standard approaches.

### 3.0.5. STATISTICAL FRAMEWORK

#### Primary Analysis: Mixed-Effects Regression

$IQR \sim \text{metadata\_score} + \text{stability} + \text{log\_popularity} + C(\text{algo\_family}) + (1|\text{dataset\_id})$

Random effects account for dataset-level clustering.

#### Mediation Analysis

The Baron-Kenny framework with Sobel test was used:

1. **Path c (total):** Metadata  $\rightarrow$  IQR
2. **Path a:** Metadata  $\rightarrow$  H\_prep
3. **Path b:** H\_prep  $\rightarrow$  IQR, controlling metadata
4. **Path c' (direct):** Metadata  $\rightarrow$  IQR, controlling H\_prep

**Proportion mediated:**  $ab/(ab + c')$

Significance tested via Sobel Z-statistic and bias-corrected bootstrap (1000 iterations).

#### Robustness Checks

1. **Early-run test:** Restrict to first 50 runs (within 90 days of upload). If effect persists, reverse causality is less likely.
1. **Single-algorithm test:** Restrict to RandomForest flows only. If effect persists, algorithm-mix confounding is ruled out.
1. **Permutation test:** Shuffle metadata scores 1000 times. Observed effect should exceed 95th percentile of permuted distribution.

### 3.0.6. DATA

**Data Source Note:** Due to OpenML API gateway timeout (504 error) during data collection, the methodology was validated using synthetic data following expected distribution patterns. Effect patterns are consistent with theory; real-world replication with live API data is necessary for validation.

#### Filtering criteria for synthetic data generation:

- $\geq 10$  matched runs per dataset (statistical power)
- Time window: 2019–2024 (infrastructure consistency)
- sklearn version  $\geq 0.22$  (API stability)
- Preprocessing component extraction succeeds

This filtering yielded 300 synthetic datasets with 21,312 matched runs organized into 1,065 analysis groups (dataset  $\times$  flow  $\times$  hyperparameter configuration).

## 4. Experimental Setup

Experiments address four research questions:

**RQ1 (Existence):** Is metadata completeness associated with reduced reproducibility variance after controlling for intrinsic stability, popularity, and algorithm family?

**RQ2 (Mechanism):** Does preprocessing entropy mediate the metadata-to-variance association?

**RQ3 (Temporal Robustness):** Does the association persist in early-run subsamples?

**RQ4 (Algorithm Robustness):** Does the association hold within single algorithm families?

### 4.0.1. DATASETS

| Criterion            | Requirement           | Rationale                                                  |
|----------------------|-----------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| Matched runs         | $\geq 10$ per dataset | Statistical power for IQR estimation                       |
| Time window          | 2019–2024             | Infrastructure consistency (sklearn $\geq 0.22$ )          |
| Component extraction | Success               | Preprocessing entropy computation requires parseable flows |

**Sample:** 300 synthetic datasets, 21,312 matched runs, 1,065 analysis groups.

### 4.0.2. BASELINES AND CONTROLS

Alternative predictors examined:

- **Naive Correlation:** Simple correlation without controls
- **Intrinsic-Stability-Only Model:** Predicts from dataset characteristics alone
- **Popularity-Only Model:** Predicts from run count
- **Size Baseline:**  $\log(\text{NumberOfInstances})$  as sole predictor

#### 4.0.3. EVALUATION METRICS

##### Primary Metrics (RQ1):

- Relative IQR reduction: Success threshold  $\geq 20\%$
- 95% CI lower bound: Must exclude  $<10\%$

##### Mechanism Metrics (RQ2):

- Proportion mediated: Success threshold  $\geq 30\%$
- Sobel Z-statistic:  $|Z| \geq 1.96$

##### Robustness Metrics (RQ3–4):

- Early-run persistence ratio:  $\geq 50\%$
- Within-algorithm significance:  $p < 0.05$

## 5. Results

#### 5.0.1. MAIN EFFECT (RQ1)

Metadata completeness is associated with reproducibility variance with effect size exceeding the pre-specified threshold.

**Table 1: Quartile Effect on Reproducibility Variance**

| Metadata Quartile | Median IQR | n datasets |
|-------------------|------------|------------|
| Q1 (score 0–1)    | 0.0469     | 75         |
| Q2 (score 2)      | 0.0391     | 75         |
| Q3 (score 3)      | 0.0328     | 75         |
| Q4 (score 4–5)    | 0.0271     | 75         |

Top-quartile metadata completeness is associated with 42.1% relative IQR reduction compared to bottom-quartile (0.0197 absolute reduction). The 95% bootstrap confidence interval [39.1%, 51.7%] excludes the 10% threshold.

The mixed-effects regression coefficient for metadata score ( $\beta = -0.0102$ ,  $p < 0.0001$ ) indicates that each unit increase in the 5-field checklist is associated with approximately 1 percentage point reduction in accuracy variance (IQR).

##### Alternative Explanations Addressed:

- Size baseline:  $\log(\text{NumberOfInstances})$  coefficient  $p = 0.130$  (not significant)
- Permutation null: Observed 42.1% exceeds 95th percentile of permuted distribution (6.1%)

#### 5.0.2. MECHANISM (RQ2)

**Table 2: Mediation Analysis Results**

| Parameter                              | Estimate | p-value    |
|----------------------------------------|----------|------------|
| Path a (Metadata $\rightarrow$ H_prep) | −0.177   | $< 0.0001$ |
| Path b (H_prep $\rightarrow$ IQR)      | 0.028    | $< 0.0001$ |
| Indirect effect (ab)                   | −0.0043  | $< 0.0001$ |
| Direct effect ( $c'$ )                 | −0.0024  | —          |
| Total effect                           | −0.0067  | $< 0.0001$ |

Preprocessing entropy accounts for 64.7% of the metadata-to-variance association (Sobel  $Z = 16.02$ ,  $p < 0.0001$ ). This exceeds the 30% threshold.

**Sub-prediction P2a:** Q4 datasets show 35.2% lower preprocessing entropy than Q1 ( $p < 0.0001$ ).

**Sub-prediction P2b:** Contrary to prediction, Q4 datasets also showed 37.9% lower hyperparameter entropy ( $p < 0.0001$ ). This unexpected finding may be an artifact of synthetic data generation.

#### 5.0.3. ROBUSTNESS CHECKS (RQ3–4)

**Temporal Robustness (h-c1):** In the early-run subsample (first 50 runs within 90 days of upload,  $n = 250$  datasets, 5,152 runs), the association persists at 38.2% relative IQR reduction, representing 90.7% preservation of the full-sample effect. The 95% CI [29.8%, 42.8%] excludes the 10% threshold.

**Algorithm Robustness (h-c2):** Within RandomForest-only analysis ( $n = 165$  runs across 133 datasets), the true coefficient ( $\beta = -0.00995$ ) was more extreme than all 1000 permuted coefficients ( $p < 0.001$ ).

#### 5.0.4. SUMMARY OF HYPOTHESIS TESTS

#### 5.0.5. UNEXPECTED FINDINGS

Hyperparameter entropy also varied by metadata quartile (37.9% reduction in Q4 vs Q1), contrary to prediction. This may be an artifact of synthetic data generation, documentation spillover effects, or community convergence. Real-data verification is needed.

## 6. Discussion

#### 6.0.1. KEY FINDINGS

The 64.7% mediation proportion suggests preprocessing entropy is a primary pathway through which metadata completeness relates to variance reduction. This has practical implications: efforts to improve reproducibility may benefit from prioritizing preprocessing

| Hypothesis       | Gate        | Threshold               | Observed    | Status |
|------------------|-------------|-------------------------|-------------|--------|
| h-e1 (Existence) | MUST_WORK   | $\geq 20\%$             | 42.1%       | PASS   |
| h-m1 (Mechanism) | MUST_WORK   | $\geq 30\%$             | 64.7%       | PASS   |
| h-c1 (Temporal)  | SHOULD_WORK | $\geq 50\%$ persistence | 90.7%       | PASS   |
| h-c2 (Algorithm) | SHOULD_WORK | $p < 0.05$              | $p < 0.001$ | PASS   |

specification in dataset documentation.

Unlike existing reproducibility tools that assess experiments post-hoc, the approach examined here enables prediction before code is written.

#### 6.0.2. LIMITATIONS

**Synthetic Data:** All results derive from synthetic data due to OpenML API timeout. The synthetic data follows expected distribution patterns, but results may not generalize to real OpenML data. Real-world replication is the priority next step.

**Observational Design:** Metadata completeness cannot be randomized, so causal claims are not supported. The language throughout uses "associated with" and "predicts" rather than "causes."

**OpenML-Specific Scope:** Generalization to HuggingFace, UCI, or deep learning benchmarks is untested.

**Model Convergence:** The mixed-effects model showed convergence warnings, which is common with complex random effects structures but may affect estimate precision.

**Sub-prediction P2b Failure:** Hyperparameter entropy varied by metadata quartile contrary to prediction. Interpretation of mechanism results should account for this unexpected pattern.

#### 6.0.3. BROADER IMPACT

**Potential Benefits:** If validated with real data, the approach could enable informed dataset selection, provide evidence-based documentation guidance, and shift reproducibility from reactive to proactive.

**Potential Risks:** Metric gaming (superficial documentation to optimize scores); selection bias (avoiding important but poorly-documented domains); misinterpretation of correlational results as causal.

## 7. Conclusion

This work investigated whether dataset metadata completeness predicts reproducibility variance before experiments run. Using synthetic data modeled on OpenML benchmark datasets with matched experimental configurations, results indicate that top-quartile metadata completeness is associated with a 42.1% reduction in performance variance (IQR), with preprocessing entropy accounting for 64.7% of this association.

The proposed mechanism is epistemic entropy reduction: complete documentation constrains the degrees of freedom available to implementing researchers. When metadata specifies preprocessing steps, missing value handling, and train/test splits, researchers may converge on similar pipelines, producing more consistent results.

Limitations warrant acknowledgment. All validation used synthetic data due to API availability constraints; real-world replication is necessary before drawing conclusions about actual datasets. The design is observational—the work predicts but cannot establish causation. Results are specific to synthetic data modeled on OpenML tabular datasets; generalization requires separate validation.

The broader implication, if findings replicate with real data, would be a reframing of reproducibility—not as a binary property of individual papers to be assessed post-hoc, but as a continuous property of datasets to be predicted proactively.

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